however, was the withdrawal symptoms that had begun to become apparent. Also, the convicts realized that the undertrials got a chance to smoke when they went to the courts but for them there was no such opportunity. This was putting them into depression. The response to this move was a mixed one, as was expressed through the petition box system. Some claimed that it was a good thing I had done but there were very vituperative and abusive responses also. I did not react to them. I was accused of having done the most stupid thing and that all my efforts at providing them better living conditions, and a more liberal atmosphere, had all come to nought.

How much of a dependence they had developed on *beedis* became apparent just 24 hours after this. The cooks said they could not work in the *langars* [free kitchens] without their *beedis*. A large number of prisoners refused to eat because of stomachaches they had developed. I wondered if my superintendents would be able to manage the situation and whether I had not bitten off more than I could chew. But then I realized what an opium-like effect their smoking had on them and that knowing this and yet permitting it would, for me, be absolutely immoral. I, therefore, let the ban continue. My superintendents cooperated with me totally. They persuaded them, they counselled them and showed determination to continue along with me. This gave me heart. The superintendents had to do a lot of excess work and face a lot of hassles but they stood by me. Without their implicit support it would just not have been possible. We kept on at it. We gave them extra milk, fruits, medicines, anything to keep their minds off smoking. It required tremendous effort but then the results started becoming apparent. I was told that their habits had started improving and that they were saying that I was very strict and that they might as well learn to do without smoking.

I recommenced my rounds in the jail. Groups started forming, some telling me I had done the right thing and some started pointing out that even the Jail Manual gave the prison in charge the prerogative of issuing two *beedis* a day to each prisoner. I said this was impossible because the logistics were too cumbersome, and also that it was not possible to find out who smoked and who did not so that the sum total would again be a situation where there was excess smoking and blackmarketing. Some of the staff members who were heavy smokers themselves were not supportive of the ban and therefore we gave them external duties where they did not have to interact with the prisoners. The situation had come to a make-or-break stage. If we could hold our own for a little while longer, then we were through; and if we failed now, then it would never be possible to attempt such a thing ever again.

Then came my most crucial test, like a bombshell. I entered the prison for one of our regular performance appraisal meetings. Normally, the prisoners would clap and thus show their approval of the way I was handling and managing things. That day there was no such clapping. I thought probably they had come to the conclusion that it was a silly thing to do and that it might be construed as hypocrisy, and that is why they had stopped the practice. My superintendent, Tarseem Kumar, had been telling me that he was facing a lot of problems here but that he was managing to cope. His problems soon became apparent. I lectured the prisoners on the reasons for the ban on smoking and tried to get the prisoners to agree with me. There was absolutely no response. So I told them it was getting late and that we would, as usual, all stand up and say our prayers. No one stood up! So I told them it was alright if they did not want to stand and that we would say our prayers sitting. There were about 1200 of them with the convicts on my right and the undertrials in front of me. I managed to get a group of the undertrials to sing along with me and then I told them to go back to their barracks. With a little persuasion the undertrials went away but the convicts remained sullen and unmoved. I told them that I would listen to their